

Board: 2

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: North

Board: 4

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: East

**Board 2**

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 10 9 6 4 2

♥ 8 5

♦ 10 7 2

♣ A J 7

♠ A 7 3

♥ A Q 9 6 4

♦ A 4 3

♣ K Q



♠ K J 8

♥ K 2

♦ Q J 9 8

♣ 10 8 5 3

♠ Q 5

♥ J 10 7 3

♦ K 6 5

♣ 9 6 4 2

West

North

East

South

Pass

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by North

1♥

Pass

2♥

With 20 points and 5-3-3-2 distribution you could correctly open 2NT.

However, many think it more important to bid a 5-card Major. In this case you decide to open 1♥. Partner responds 2♥.

Partner promised 6-10 points. With your 19 you decide to bid game.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♦Q.

**North plays 4♥. East leads the ♦Q.**

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 5

One of the ♠ losers will be ruffed in dummy so you really just have to eliminate one loser.

It is very tempting to win the first trick in dummy and immediately finesse West for the ♥K. If the finesse works then all will be well, but if it fails another ♦ will knock out your ♦A. Then, when the defense gets into the lead with a ♠ or ♣ they will cash their ♦ winner.

Here is a better idea. Win the first trick in your hand with the ♦A, and immediately lead a low ♠ toward the ♠Q. If East holds the ♠K he is caught in the middle. If he ducks you play the ♠Q and don't lose any ♠s. If he goes up you can win a later trick with the ♠Q and dump dummy's ♦ loser on your ♠A.

Declarers in suit contracts tend to focus on trumps, they want to pull them right away. And for good reason, that is usually the best Plan.

But there are many situations when that is **NOT** the best plan. Perhaps because you need to ruff something in dummy, or perhaps (like this hand) because playing trumps would give the timing to the defense.

In this deal pulling trumps is secondary to finding a place for that slow ♦ loser.

**Board 4**

East Deals

Both Vul

♠ K J 6  
 ♥ Q J 8 6 2  
 ♦ 6 4 2  
 ♣ 9 3

♠ 10 8 5 3  
 ♥ 9 4  
 ♦ K J 10  
 ♣ K 8 7 2



♠ 7 2  
 ♥ A K 10 7 3  
 ♦ A 8 3  
 ♣ A 5 4

♠ A Q 9 4  
 ♥ 5  
 ♦ Q 9 7 5  
 ♣ Q J 10 6

| West | North | East | South |
|------|-------|------|-------|
|      |       | 1♥   | Pass  |

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by East

would eliminate one of the ♠ losers - that would at least get you to down only 1.

You open 1♥ and partner jumps to 4♥. You pass.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♣Q.

**East plays 4♥. South leads the ♣Q.**

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 1 : Total = 5

The ♣ losers are shown as 1 since you will always be able to ruff a ♣ in dummy.

West's precipitous leap to 4♥ was made partly in hopes of making the contract, and partly as a preemptive bid to shut the opponents up. So it wouldn't be a surprise to land in an unmakeable contract. However, this one has a slim chance. The only suit you might make something of is ♠s. If South holds the ♠A then leading up to the ♠K

Or, if South holds the ♠Q and North the ♠A then leading up to the ♠J would also eliminate one ♠ loser. But this play has another advantage - if South should happen to hold **BOTH** the ♠A and ♠Q then leading up to the ♠J will actually let you make the contract. So you win the ♣A, pull two trumps, then play a ♠ to the ♠J. If that wins, back to your hand with a trump and play your other ♠ to the ♠K.

Some times you don't really expect to make a contract - this is one of those times.

But you should still ask yourself if there is some distribution that will allow you to be successful. And if there is, just assume that distribution and boldly play the cards out.